

Participatory Dialogues to Inform a Situated Reading Mediation Guide

Preliminary feasibility conditions in Ocuiltzapoyo, San Martín Chalchicuautla, San Luis Potosí

Casa Tlacuacha Community Library

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1. Background

In 2023, the first Little Neighborhood Library was established in a rural community in Tamazunchale. Initially, it operated through the free exchange of books. However, despite two rounds of restocking and the introduction of usage guidelines, the collection dwindled again.

This experience highlighted the limitations of book access alone to encourage library use. It prompted reflection on how reading mediation could respond to the community's context and on the conditions needed to design a locally relevant intervention.

2. Problem Statement

Access to books is necessary but insufficient to foster library use. Previous experience suggested the need for a reading mediation guide that is grounded in the local territory and responsive to community needs and interests.

This led to the following research question:

What feasibility conditions can be identified through participatory dialogues with children and adults in Ocuiltzapoyo, San Luis Potosí, to select an element of natural heritage to inform the subsequent design of a situated reading mediation guide?

3. Objective

To analyze preliminary feasibility conditions emerging from two participatory dialogues with children and adults and select a natural heritage element to inform the subsequent design of a situated reading mediation guide.

4. Theoretical Foundations

Pierre Bourdieu: Theory of Cultural Capital
Access to books does not ensure their appropriation; the social conditions shaping people's relationship with books matter.

Paulo Freire: Dialogic Pedagogy
Participatory dialogue provides a way to explore community knowledge and perspectives rather than impose an externally defined intervention.

Michèle Petit: Reading Mediation
Reading becomes meaningful when connecting books with people's experiences, cultural references, and territory.

5. Methodology

Approach: Qualitative

Scope: Exploratory-descriptive

Orientation: Participatory

Design: Situated case study

Participants: 7 children (ages 8–10) and 6 adults

Data Generation: Participatory dialogues, drawings, written activities, and individual forms

Documentation: Audio recordings, transcripts

6. Procedure

1. Introduction and future library
2. Dialogue with children
3. Dialogue with adults
4. Initial coding
5. Triangulation of evidence
6. Workshop & reading mediation guide

7. Fieldwork



Mediator at the first community library, 2023



Dialogue with children in the community of Ocuiltzapoyo



Workshop: "An introduction to poetry through cacao." UASLP, 2026



Bird of a Thousand Ways.
"Pájaro de las mil maneras".

8. Results: Thematic Relevance

- Both groups created drawings, texts, and dialogue that show diverse interests in flora, fauna, landscape, and housing.
- Children link their choices to everyday experiences, emotions, stories, and curiosity.

- Adults contribute local knowledge, memories, and criteria for care
- Key differences: Adults emphasize risks and care while children emphasize narratives, palm houses, and birds with local names



9. Results: Operational Viability

Implementation

Both dialogues were conducted using the available space and materials. The planned activities were completed with adaptations.

Adaptations and challenges

- The children's dialogue took place first, reversing the planned sequence.

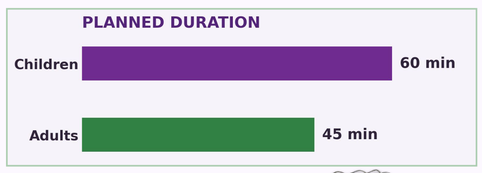
- The final prioritization activity was adapted as the school break approached.

- Distance, transportation and interruptions affected implementation.

Operational finding

The dialogues were feasible to conduct and generated records to inform the future reading mediation guide. More time for prioritization and a separate checklist for each dialogue are recommended.

Evidence: dialogue design, checklist, field notes and transcripts.





10. Central finding

The dialogues proved feasible for gathering knowledge, interests, stories, and conditions of care. They also identified intergenerational similarities and generated useful materials for a future guide. However, children's prioritization resulted in a tie between landscape and flor amor de un rato, each with seven expressions of interest. Adults prioritized flowers. Therefore, flor amor de un rato emerged as a possible intergenerational choice.

Casa Tlacuacha Library

- Design the first reading mediation sequence.
- Select a story or poem related to the selected element.
- Integrate reading, conversation, drawing, and literary creation.
- Pilot the guide.
- Gradually install the six community libraries.
- Compile the children's creations in a book or resource available in the libraries.
- Subsequently evaluate the use of the guide and the libraries.



Design of 1 of the 6 libraries to be installed in the Huasteca Potosina region.

Digital Possibilities

Opportunities and Risks

- Library science trends point toward digital access as part of the library's mission (IFLA-UNESCO, 2022), and AI could support digitizing community knowledge, with the community feeding the library its territorial knowledge.
- Access to books alone does not generate a bond; trust, reading mediation and shared encounter does
- Digitizing risks providing access to unreliable AI models for Huastecan Nahuatl, extractive use of children's voices, and overlooking unequal energy access.

Proposal

- Critical digital literacy for children and families.
- Community data governance, guided by local digital sovereignty.
- Locally owned, offline-capable infrastructure.
- AI as a reviewable aid, never a linguistic authority.
- An approach adaptable to other languages and territories.

• Freire, P. (2018). Education as the Practice of Freedom. Siglo XXI Editores.
• Petit, M. (1999). New Approaches to Young People and Reading. Fondo de Cultura Económica.
• Bourdieu, P. (1987). "The Three States of Cultural Capital."